

US Ministry Snapshot

Through the Eyes of Pastor Enoch Liao

Boston Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC) – Boston, Massachusetts

Interviewed by Pastor Enoch Liao | CCCOWE 2026 Explore360, Kuching, Malaysia

Pastor Enoch Liao is in the first generation of his family born in the United States. His parents and his grandparents on both sides all immigrated — his parents born in China, raised in Taiwan, arriving as graduate students — placing his family in the second wave of Chinese migration to America that he will describe below. He does not use "second-generation" or "1.5-generation" to describe himself; his framing is simpler and more precise: he is the first generation of his family born here. He serves as lead English pastor at Boston Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC), a congregation with roots in Boston's Chinatown that was founded in 1965 and has since grown to include a suburban campus as well. He has been in pastoral ministry for more than twenty-five years — at BCEC since 2001 — has contributed chapters to the edited volume *Letter to the Asian American Church*, and has been an active voice in the emerging Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative. BCEC is, by his own description, not racially diverse — it is predominantly Chinese — but diverse across nearly every other axis that matters: class, educational background, language, national origin, generation, and political conviction. He speaks from a context shaped by a century of American immigration policy, the geography of the Boston region, and a range of Chinese diaspora histories that no single wave of migration could produce on its own.

The three pastors on the Explore360 map are not a convenience sample. Bert Han in Birmingham, Billy Lo in Stockholm, and Enoch Liao in Boston have each pastored for more than twenty-five years, and the three are the cases in Enoch's doctoral research: a grounded theory study of healthy pastoral longevity in the Chinese heritage church. What follows is not a survey. It is one pastor's account of what he has seen, navigated, and learned — in a context that looks quite unlike any other stop on the Explore360 map.

▪ Start With a Question: How Many Generations Are in Your Church?

Ask a room of pastors how many generations are in a Chinese heritage church and most will reach for the familiar ladder: first generation, second generation, perhaps a third. The ladder feels complete because in most of the diaspora it is. In Birmingham, the church is being remade by a first-generation wave. In Stockholm, forty years of history still sit largely within two generations of immigration.

Hold the question. The American story will come back to it, and the honest answer is longer than the ladder.

▪ Who Are the People? A Century in One Congregation

The story of who is sitting in a Chinese heritage church in the United States is inseparable from the story of American immigration law. The Chinese heritage church in America is over 150 years old, and the waves are still arriving.

The first wave of Chinese in America arrived during the Gold Rush of the late 1800s. They built the railroads, populated the Chinatowns of the major coastal cities, and — when the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 slammed the door — stayed and made something out of what they had. Boston's Chinatown is one of those communities. BCEC was founded in 1965, in that neighborhood, serving people who could trace their Chinese-American roots back generations. The third- and fourth-generation Chinese Americans who grew up in that church are, in some cases, the grandchildren or great-grandchildren of Gold Rush-era migrants. Their relationship to China is historical, not personal.

The second wave arrived after the Hart-Celler Immigration Act of 1965 reopened the door. This time the migrants were largely university-educated: graduate students and professionals from Taiwan and mainland China who came to American campuses for advanced degrees and stayed. Enoch's own family belongs to this wave. "My parents were born in China and raised in Taiwan," he says — a sentence that contains, in eleven words, the compressed history of twentieth-century Chinese politics: civil war, displacement, the Nationalist retreat to Taiwan, and a graduate school application to an American university.

The third wave came out of Hong Kong in the decades before and after the 1997 handover. Some came early, in the 1980s, reading the political signals correctly. Others arrived in the 1990s and early 2000s. They brought a Cantonese-speaking, Hong Kong-formed church culture that overlapped with but was distinct from the Mandarin-speaking mainland-Taiwan community that had preceded them. The same geographic vectors that sent Hong Kongers to Birmingham and Stockholm also sent them to Boston — but in the United States, they arrived into a Chinese heritage church ecosystem already shaped by two prior waves.

The fourth wave began roughly in the mid-2000s and continued through the early 2010s: mainland Chinese students coming to American universities in large numbers, many on temporary student visas and planning to return to China. This group differs from the post-1965 wave in one important respect — their trajectory is often not permanent settlement. They are present in American Chinese heritage churches for a season, and they know it.

BCEC holds all four of these histories under one roof, across two campuses. The result is a congregation that defies easy description. A first-generation mainland Chinese student from a

wealthy family planning to return to Shanghai sits near a fourth-generation Chinese American who has never been to China and does not speak Mandarin. A Hong Konger carrying political grief about the 2019 protests sits beside someone who has a different read on that history entirely. Enoch does not describe this multiplicity as a problem to solve. He describes it as the texture of the community he has been given.

▪ Was There a Silent Exodus?

For nearly thirty years, one story has governed how the church talks about the children of Chinese and other Asian immigrants in America. In 1996, *Christianity Today* published Helen Lee's article "Silent Exodus," asking whether the East Asian church in America could reverse the flight of its next generation. The phrase outgrew the article. It hardened into an operating assumption: the second generation leaves, the English ministry is a leaky bucket, the immigrant church cannot keep its children.

Enoch's contention is that this story has been narrated far more than it has been measured. When sociologists finally measured it, the strongest version of the story did not survive contact with the data.

- **Two-thirds actually stayed.** Analyzing the Pew Research Center's 2012 survey of Asian Americans, sociologists Jerry Z. Park and Joshua Tom found that 66 percent of Asian Americans who grew up Protestant were still Protestant when surveyed. Their conclusion is worth quoting in full: "Either way we look at the data, there does not appear to be a mass exodus, if nearly two-thirds who started their faith journey as Protestants are still Protestant."
- **Most who left joined the "nones," like all of America.** The departures that did happen were largely a drift into religious non-affiliation, not conversion to another faith. And that drift was a national tide, not a Chinese heritage church peculiarity: American religious non-affiliation roughly doubled, from about 10 percent to about 20 percent, in a single decade. The second generation's departures ran into the same category the whole country was pouring into.
- **We mostly hear from the churches that are struggling.** Pastors compare notes with pastors who share their pain. Churches that quietly kept their young people rarely write articles about it. The narrative fed on the loudest losses.
- **Those who stayed go to church more than white Protestants.** This is the counter-fact Enoch leads with. Carolyn Chen and Jerry Z. Park, in a 2019 peer-reviewed study, found that second-generation Asian American Protestants attend religious services more often than Protestants in the general population. The ones who remain are more committed, not lukewarm — and they largely form their own congregations rather than being absorbed into white churches.

Enoch is careful not to overclaim. The data does not say nothing happened. Chen and Park found second-generation Asian American Protestant retention somewhat below the general American Protestant rate, and disaffiliation somewhat above it. And no rigorous, survey-tier, Chinese-specific congregational dropout figure exists at all: how many American-born Chinese actually left the Chinese heritage church remains undocumented, not disproven. But undocumented is the point. A generation of ministry strategy was built on a story that was never measured — and the parts that have now been measured contradict its strongest form.

Sources: Carolyn Chen and Jerry Z. Park, "Pathways of Religious Assimilation: Second-Generation Asian Americans' Religious Retention and Religiosity," *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 58, no. 3 (2019); Jerry Z. Park and Joshua Tom, "Keeping (and Losing) Faith, the Asian American Way," *AAPI Voices*, 2014, analyzing the Pew Research Center 2012 Asian American Survey.

▪ The Reveal: Fourth and Fifth Generation

Now return to the opening question. How many generations are in your church? In the United States, the honest ladder does not stop at three. It runs to four, and to five.

Enoch does not need the literature to make the point. "My adult kids are fourth and fifth generation," he says. "Fourth on my side. Fifth on my wife's." Children of the Chinese heritage church, raised in the Chinese heritage church, four and five generations from the boat.

These are the people the silent exodus narrative says should not exist. If the church loses its children as a rule, there is no fourth generation, let alone a fifth. Their existence does not settle every question, but it should unsettle the assumption.

▪ Two Questions for Leaders

Enoch turns the finding back on those of us who lead, because the silent exodus story survived on habits of mind that every pastor recognizes.

- 1 Do we assume every church is like our church? A pastor watching his own English ministry shrink will find the exodus story irresistible, because it universalizes his experience. But one congregation is not a dataset.
- 2 Do we seek out others who share our struggle, or also those further down the road? Fellowship among the discouraged is real comfort and poor cartography. The churches several generations deep have maps the struggling churches need.

▪ If There Was No Exodus, What Now?

The reframe is not an occasion for relief. It is an invitation to work.

- **Look beyond churches that may have a different experience than yours.** The American Chinese heritage church includes congregations at every point of the arc: some flooded with newcomers, some rebuilding, some formed people four and five generations deep.
- **Ask what theology and assumptions we may need to reconsider.** If strategy was built on an unmeasured story, some of the theology stretched over that strategy needs re-examining too.
- **Reconsider a biblical definition of diversity.** The popular American evangelical argument for the multiethnic church often rests on Revelation 6 and 7: the vision of every nation, tribe, and tongue gathered before the throne. That is a beautiful vision. The problem is that this exegesis has been used to underwrite churches that are majority-white in culture, with minority pastoral hires and diverse faces in the pews. That is not biblical diversity. It is majority-culture church with a different aesthetic.

Enoch's alternative is what he has called, in *Letter to the Asian American Church*, "a diversity of diversities." The typical US Chinese heritage church may be more diverse than a typical white American megachurch: generational diversity, linguistic diversity, cultural diversity, political diversity, national diversity, socioeconomic diversity, and ethnic and racial diversity, all under one roof. A congregation like BCEC is not failing at diversity because it is predominantly Chinese. It is practicing forms of diversity the megachurch never attempts.

▪ The Hidden Tension: Complexity Without Infrastructure

When asked about the hardest tensions at a Chinese heritage church, the expected answers are cultural and generational: the gap between first-generation Chinese speakers and English-speaking young people, the friction between different immigrant communities, the political differences that COVID made visible. All of those are real. But the tension Enoch names as the most persistent, and the most underappreciated, is organizational.

Chinese heritage churches are extraordinarily complex organizations. A single congregation may run services in two or three languages, with different worship styles, different pastoral teams, different generational cultures, and very different expectations about how decisions get made. The Chinese heritage church in America has built this complexity largely without the organizational development tools — the elder training, the governance frameworks, the staff formation practices — that might help sustain it. The result is churches that are impressive in their breadth and fragile in their structure. The complexity is real; the infrastructure to hold it is often not.

▪ What a Healthy Church Actually Forms

Enoch frames healthy Chinese heritage church ministry around a fourfold paradigm: the Word of God, the People of God, the Spirit of God, and the Mission of God. None of the four can be subordinated to the others without something being lost. A church strong on Word and thin on community will not form people well. A church strong on Spirit but thin on mission will turn inward. The four together describe a church that is genuinely formative — not just culturally preserving, not just organizationally functional, but actually producing disciples.

What makes this fourfold frame distinctive in a Chinese heritage context is what Enoch insists belongs inside it: ethnic heritage. He is direct about this. "I believe God made us that way and wants us to understand that. I don't think you're supposed to erase your background. I think you're supposed to bring them all — by the grace of God — into your identity in Christ." This is not a concession to cultural sentiment. It is a theological claim about the relationship between particularity and the gospel. The goal is not Chinese people who happen to be Christians. It is disciples who are whole people — including their Chinese heritage, including their ethnic history, including the parts of that history that are painful.

The practical implication shows up in discipleship content. In the United States, especially in regions where Chinese Americans are a small numerical minority, internalized racial shame is a real pastoral issue. The experience of growing up Asian in America — navigating a majority culture that either exoticizes or ignores you, struggling to locate yourself in a racial landscape built around Black and white, inheriting a family's silence about history — does not resolve itself by not talking about it in church. Ethnic identity formation, Enoch argues, is not a cultural preference. It is a discipleship necessity.

What is getting in the way? The organizational fragility described above. And underneath it: the geographic and economic logic of the American city. English-speaking Chinese American young people who grew up in Chinese heritage churches often move away for college and do not return. This is partly about life stage, but it is also about geography and economics. Many Chinese heritage churches that have established English ministries are in expensive suburban neighborhoods. A twenty-three-year-old finishing college and building a life on an entry-level salary cannot afford to live where the church is. They find a church wherever they can afford to live — and that church is usually not a Chinese heritage church. Note what this is: a housing market, not an exodus of faith.

Enoch points to the English ministry at the Chinese Christian Church of Rhode Island (CCCRI) — the only Chinese heritage church in the state — as a model for thinking about this differently. That ministry functions as a sending church: it forms people well, releases them into other communities and other cities, and sends them out carrying something durable. The numbers are not large. But the people formed there carry something real. A sending ministry is still a healthy ministry. Numbers are not the only measure of formation.

▪ The Long American Arc — and What Is New

The United States has been doing Chinese heritage ministry long enough to produce third- and fourth-generation Chinese Americans — and in some families, fifth. This is not a UK reality or a Nordic reality. Bert Han in Birmingham is navigating a BNO wave of first-generation Hong Kongers who have never raised children in a country where they do not share the language. Billy Lo in Stockholm is working with a community that has been in the Nordic countries for forty years but is still largely within two generations of immigration. The American context is different in kind, not just in degree.

The literature reflects this. Sociologists like Fenggang Yang, author of *Chinese Christians in America*, have documented the Chinese Christian community in America over decades. Russell Jeung's *Faithful Generations* traced the formation of new Asian American churches and the institutional patterns that emerged across multiple generations. Enoch reads this work carefully — and reads it with some skepticism. He is not convinced that the generational data Jeung assembled in the early 2000s maps cleanly onto what he sees now. The landscape has shifted since those books were written, the silent exodus story they were written under has been re-measured, and the Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative did not exist when they went to press.

What is genuinely new, in Enoch's reading, is the ethnic revitalization impulse among younger Chinese Americans. Some of it is a response to anti-Asian racism — the surge in anti-Asian violence during and after the COVID pandemic made visible a hostility that had always been present but was easier to deny. Some of it is a broader cultural moment: a generation across many backgrounds recovering what assimilation pressures asked their parents and grandparents to set aside. Enoch sees it concretely. Young Chinese Americans are reclaiming their given Chinese names. Names that were anglicized at some point in the family history — by immigration officials, by parents trying to make life easier, by a young person who wanted to fit in — are being recovered. That is not a trivial gesture. It is a statement about identity.

What Enoch is sure of: the Chinese heritage church in America has something to offer that no other kind of congregation can fully supply. That something is ethnic identity formation rooted in the gospel — formation that helps a Chinese American understand who they are as a person, as a Chinese person, as a follower of Christ, as all three at once. It is not for everyone. But for a growing number of young Chinese Americans who want to be whole rather than hybrid, it may be exactly what they are looking for.

▪ The Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative, 2019 to 2027

For Chinese heritage churches, this moment is an opening, and the Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative is the bet placed on it: not to write these churches off, but to strengthen them from

within, building English ministries that are theologically robust, ethnically grounded, and capable of forming the people the old narrative assumed did not exist.

- **2019** — Pastors Colloquium, an invite-only gathering of pastors in Boston
- **2020** — Online gatherings (Zoom)
- **2023** — First National Gathering, Houston
- **2024** — Two Regional Gatherings
- **2025** — National Gathering
- **2026** — Two Regional Gatherings
- **2027** — National Gathering / Ministers Collective (tentative: Chicagoland, Illinois, May 2027)

Whether the bet pays off is the live question. The trajectory so far, from one invite-only colloquium to a sustained national rhythm, suggests the people it serves were there all along.

▪ **Many Variables. One Sovereign God.**

Enoch resists any single-factor explanation of why one Chinese heritage church flourishes and another declines. God sovereignly uses many factors to shape each local Chinese heritage church, among them:

- Immigration patterns
- Socioeconomic status
- Size and numbers
- Racialization
- The strength of the wider evangelical church

These are the variables he is studying. The confession underneath the study is simpler: many variables, one sovereign God. The same God who carried a Gold Rush congregation through the Exclusion Act is at work in a fourth-wave student Bible study, in a BNO family in Birmingham, and in a fifth-generation kid in Boston who is reclaiming her Chinese name.

*Pastor Enoch Liao serves as lead English pastor at Boston Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC) in Boston, Massachusetts. He is a contributor to the edited volume *Letter to the Asian American Church* and has been an active voice in the Chinese Heritage Church Collaborative. This snapshot draws on his doctoral research, a grounded theory study of healthy pastoral longevity in the Chinese heritage church, of which Bert Han, Billy Lo, and Enoch Liao are the three cases. It was prepared for the CCCOWE 2026 Explore360 breakout session, "The Evolving Chinese Church Around the Globe," Kuching, Malaysia, July 21–22, 2026.*